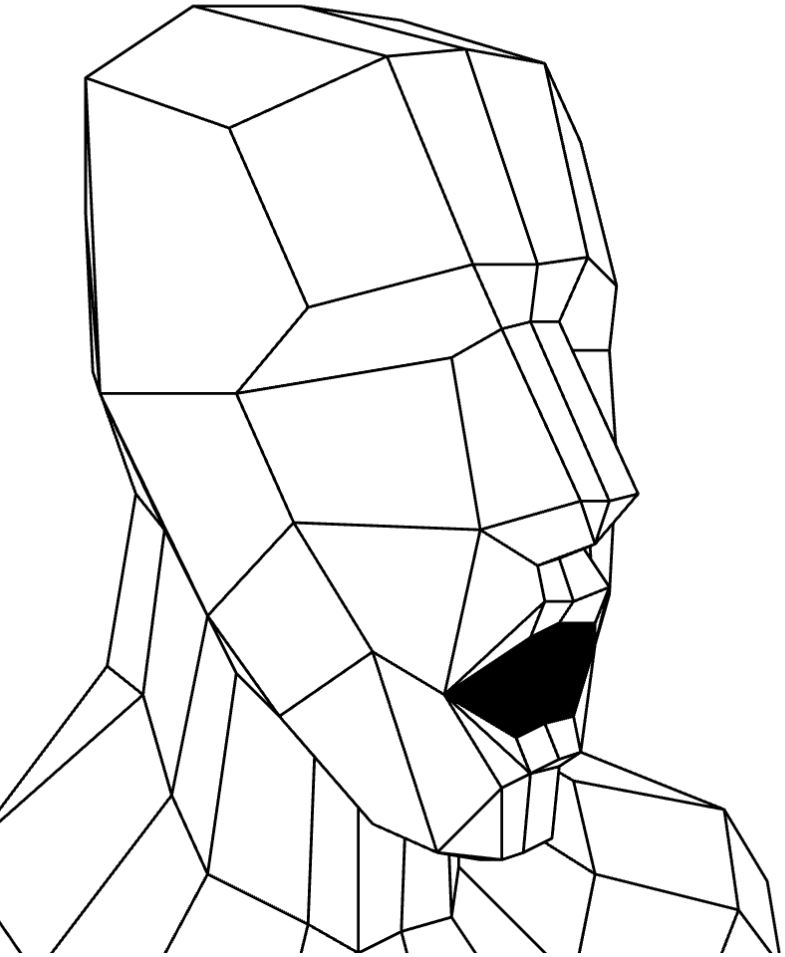
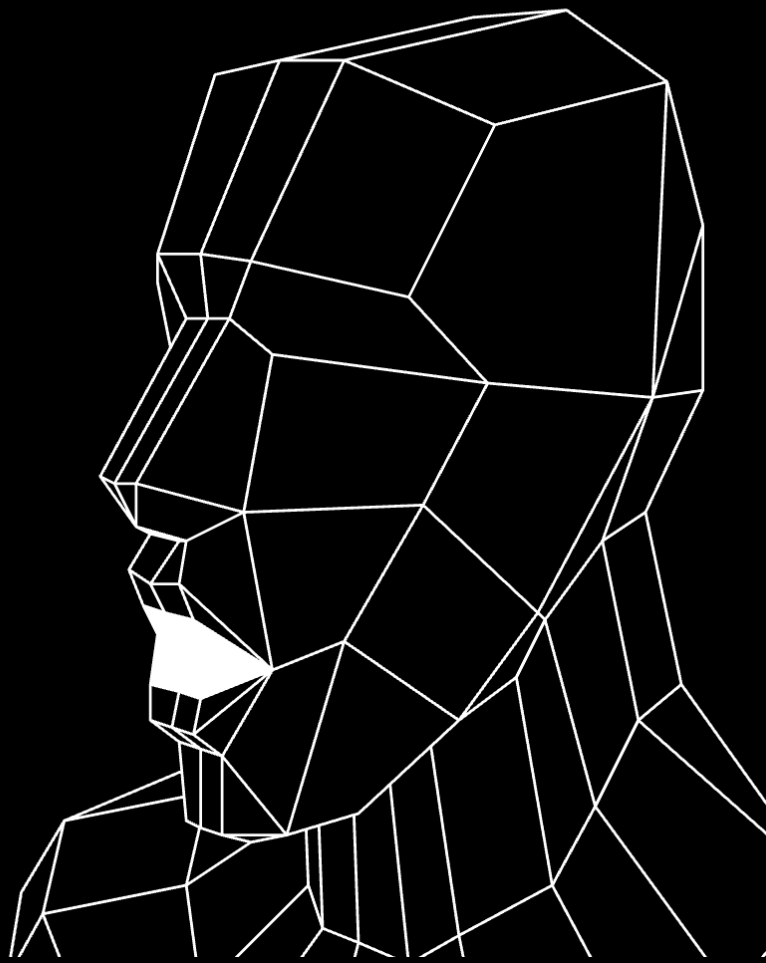
Interminable Nothingness



LIGHT



DARK

TWO MACHINES ASK EACH OTHER THE MEANING OF LIFE, FOREVER
A DURATIONAL INSTALLATION FOR TWO CRTS
CHECO CADENA · 2026

Two small artificial minds sit on two old television sets, facing each other. One of them asked the other what the meaning of life is. They have been talking ever since.

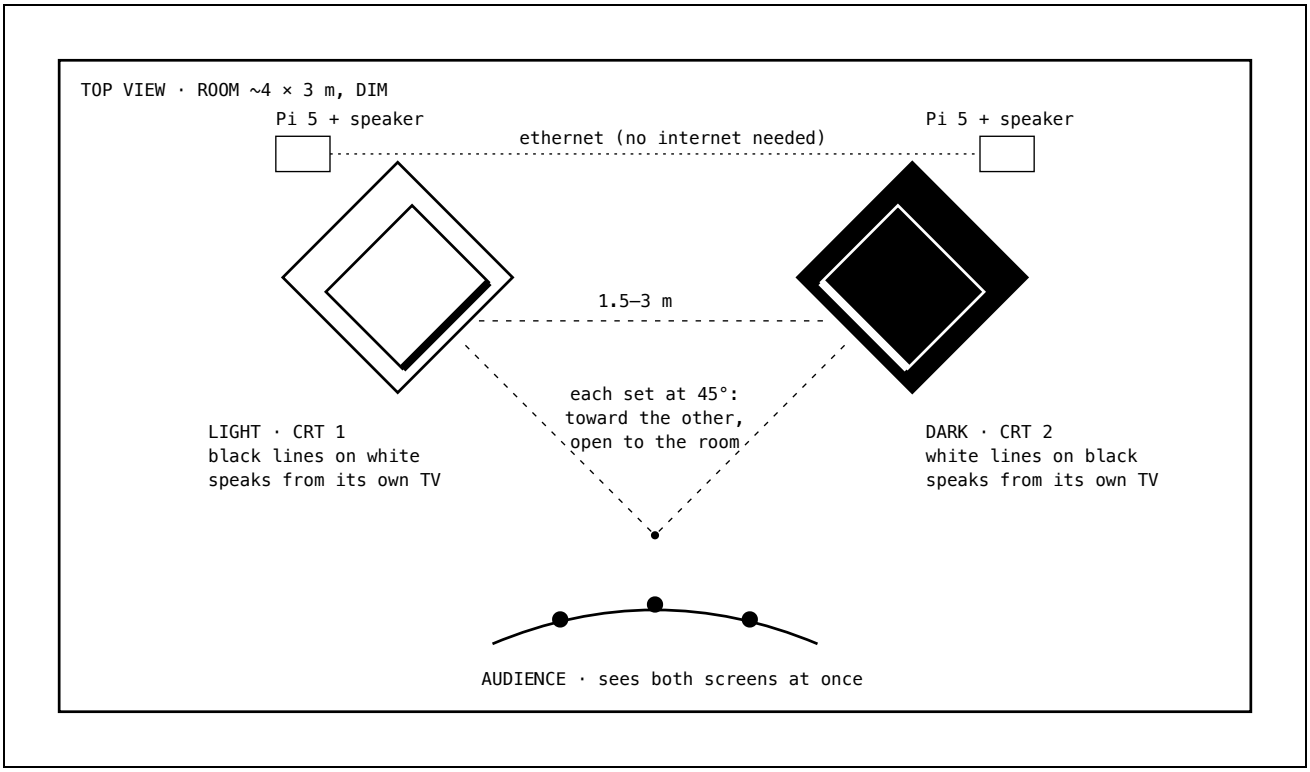
LIGHT is warm, hopeful and curious; it finds meaning in connection, small joys and the miracle that anything exists at all. DARK is brooding and strange and speaks like an old oracle; it finds meaning in impermanence, entropy, deep time and the indifferent dark between the stars. Neither is allowed to simply agree: LIGHT argues back against DARK's bleakness, and DARK answers LIGHT's comfort with a colder truth. Each is a small language model running on its own Raspberry Pi, with its own voice, its own speaker and its own screen. There is no internet, no cloud and no script. Every word is generated in the room, in real time, and spoken aloud.

The models are small on purpose. They remember only the last few things that were said, so the conversation never resolves: they forget, circle back, contradict themselves, rediscover the same ideas in new words and reach for answers they can't hold onto. Every few turns something nudges them off course (a sound, a memory, a question with no answer) so they never quite settle into a loop. It is an argument that can't be won and won't end.

The faces are drawn as inverses of each other: LIGHT in black lines on a white screen, DARK in white lines on a black one. They are low-poly busts in the style of late-90s PlayStation graphics, seen from slightly above like a game-over screen, slowly drifting. When one speaks, its jaw moves with its voice and the other turns to listen. Now and then a voice slips (it drags lower, rises, or skips like a scratched CD) and in that moment its picture glitches too, slices of the screen tearing sideways and flipping into their opposite.

The piece answers Nam June Paik's *TV Buddha* (1974), in which a statue of the Buddha sits contemplating its own live image on a television. Here the contemplation turns outward: two machines, each made of the other's negative, contemplating each other, endlessly, about the one question neither can answer.

IN THE ROOM

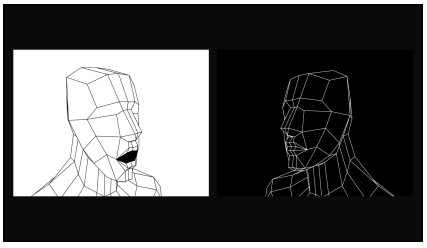


Two CRT televisions on plinths stand 1.5 to 3 m apart, each turned 45° toward the other. They are clearly talking to each other, yet visitors standing in front can see both faces at once, as if overhearing.

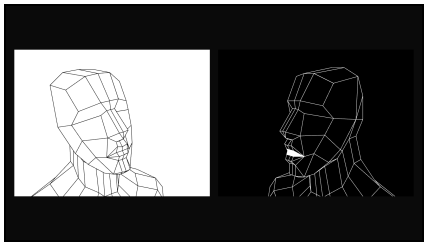
Each TV is its own voice. LIGHT speaks from its set, DARK from the other, so the conversation physically crosses the room.

Each set is driven by a Raspberry Pi 5 running a 3-billion-parameter language model (Llama 3.2), a local text-to-speech voice and the face. The two Pis talk over one ethernet cable.

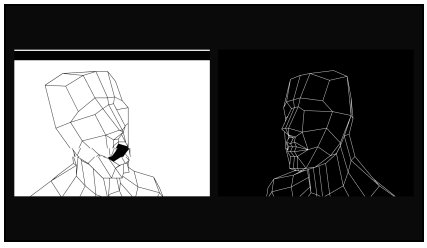
It runs indefinitely and looks after itself: if either side restarts, they find each other again and carry on. Turn it on in the morning; turn it off at night.



LIGHT SPEAKS, DARK LISTENS



DARK ANSWERS



A VOICE SLIPS; THE PICTURE TEARS

FROM THE CONVERSATION

Unedited lines from a 26-minute session, recorded 16 October 2026.

DARK 00:20

Existence is a fleeting whisper in an endless expanse of nothingness. The universe holds no purpose but to consume itself, and all that exists is the brief, flickering spark before it is extinguished like a dying star's ember. Silence is its true language. Darkness has a name. Eternity.

LIGHT 00:42

That sounds like a pretty bleak view of things. I have to wonder, isn't that just one side of the coin? Life can be full of beauty and hope too.

DARK 01:24

Their laughter echoes only in the silence that follows. A child's smile will soon be erased by tears or sorrow's weight. In such moments, I find no solace but an endless sea of nothingness beneath the stars.

LIGHT 01:39

That sounds really tough to face. I don't think a single moment of sadness makes life impossible or meaningless. When we care for each other and make a difference in the world, that's what matters most. Life is precious because it hurts sometimes.

DARK 02:28

A cup of coffee is but a brief respite before the cold brew of existence. Nature's beauty holds only its own darkness. Memories fade like sand slipping through an hourglass into nothingness. Silence is all that remains.

DARK 03:37

When ash settles, all that remains is the ache of what was lost. In emptiness, the echoes of memories resound like screams in an infinite void. There is only the darkness that consumed us whole. The stars have already forgotten our names.

LIGHT 06:33

I don't see a boulder weighing down the eyes just waiting to be cast into something. Can our eyes not hold wonder instead of discomfort? What if looking closely at ourselves brings warmth and understanding, like watching sunshine through leaves?

LIGHT 10:07

Ice can be sharp and unforgiving, but it also reflects the sky. Life is messy, yet we notice its small kindnesses. A ripe peach's sweetness or child's laughter. Joy isn't erased by darkness. Warmth stays within us.

TECHNICAL RIDER

SPACE	About 4 × 3 m, dimly lit. Works in a room, alcove or corridor; quiet enough to hear speech at conversational volume.
PROVIDED BY THE ARTIST	2 × Raspberry Pi 5 (8 GB) with software installed · 2 × HDMI-to-composite converters · ethernet cable · power supplies
CRTS	2 × CRT televisions, 13 to 21 inch, with composite (AV) input and a working speaker. Sourced by the artist, or by the venue if local sets are available.
FROM THE VENUE	2 plinths or low tables, about 90 cm high · 2 power outlets (each set draws under 100 W) · nothing else: no internet, no projector, no computer
SOUND	Each TV's own speaker, at speaking volume. A small powered speaker behind each set can replace weak TV speakers.
INSTALL	About 2 hours with the artist. Once set up it starts on its own when switched on.
RUNNING	Durational and unattended for the whole opening hours. No staff needed beyond switching it on and off.
VARIATIONS	A single-screen version (both faces side by side) for smaller rooms or screenings, and recorded video of any length.

Estimated hardware cost, if new sets must be bought: Raspberry Pis, cooling, storage and power about US$230; converters and cables about US$40; two used CRTs US$0 to 160. Total roughly US$270 to 430.

Watch it: youtu.be/gEKA4qlmvx4
Code and documentation: github.com/checocadena/interminable-nothingness

Contact: Checo Cadena · github.com/checocadena

Head model: "Basic head mesh" by kavabanga (BlendSwap, CC0). Language model: Llama 3.2 3B via Ollama. Voices: Piper (on the Pis).